COLOSSIANS · STUDY 06 OF 12

Colossians 2:8–15

Beware of Philosophy

Christ Is All — A Study of Colossians

Small Group Bible Study Series · NASB95

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① Text	② Devotional	③ Commentary	④ Self-Study Guide
Foundation	Personal preparation	Teacher / leader preparation	Group meeting
Everyone	*All group members*	*Teacher / leader*	*Small group*

⑤ *Application closes each study and draws from all sections above.*

Time guide: about 30 minutes — Devotional 4 · Commentary 15 · Discussion 8 · Application 3.

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① BIBLICAL TEXT

Colossians 2:8–15 · New American Standard Bible (NASB95)

2:8 *See to it that no one takes you captive through philosophy and empty deception, according to the tradition of men, according to the elementary principles of the world, rather than according to Christ.*

9 *For in Him all the fullness of Deity dwells in bodily form,*

10 *and in Him you have been made complete, and He is the head over all rule and authority;*

11 *and in Him you were also circumcised with a circumcision made without hands, in the removal of the body of the flesh by the circumcision of Christ;*

12 *having been buried with Him in baptism, in which you were also raised up with Him through faith in the working of God, who raised Him from the dead.*

13 *When you were dead in your transgressions and the uncircumcision of your flesh, He made you alive together with Him, having forgiven us all our transgressions,*

14 *having canceled out the certificate of debt consisting of decrees against us, which was hostile to us; and He has taken it out of the way, having nailed it to the cross.*

15 *When He had disarmed the rulers and authorities, He made a public display of them, having triumphed over them through Him.*

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② DEVOTIONAL

Personal preparation · Drawn from the outline of this study

Complete in Him

> *“For in Him all the fullness of Deity dwells in bodily form, and in Him you have been made complete”*
>
> *— Colossians 2:9–10 (NASB95)*

There is a quiet voice that whispers to many believers: "You are almost there, but not quite. You need one more experience, one more rule, one more secret." Paul calls that voice what it is: philosophy and empty deception, built on human tradition and the elementary principles of the world, and not according to Christ.

Then he lays down the truth that silences it. All the fullness of Deity lives in Christ in bodily form, and in Him you have been made complete. Not "will be," not "might be," but "have been." What could anyone add to the One who is the fullness of God and who lives in you?

And look at what is already yours. A circumcision made without hands. Burial and resurrection with Christ. Every transgression forgiven. The certificate of debt canceled and nailed to the cross. Every hostile power disarmed and paraded in defeat. You have nothing to fear from spirits or superstitions. Greater is He who is in you.

For reflection

1. What "one more thing" have you been tempted to think would make you complete before God?
2. How does knowing that "all our transgressions" are forgiven change the way you approach God in prayer?
3. Are there fears of unseen powers or superstitions that still have a grip on you?

You are complete in Him. Live from that fullness, not toward it.

③ COMMENTARY

Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings

> **The passage teaches:** Believers must beware of any man-made philosophy that is not according to Christ, because all the fullness of Deity dwells in Christ bodily and believers are complete in Him, having received in Him a spiritual circumcision, union in His burial and resurrection, full forgiveness, the cancellation of the debt of the Law, and victory over every hostile power.

Outline

- **I. Beware of Philosophy (2:8)**
  - A. It Is Deceptive
  - B. It Is Man-Made
  - C. It Is Worldly
  - D. It Is Not According to Christ
- **II. Be Aware of Christ (2:9–10)**
  - A. His Deity
  - B. His Humanity
  - C. Our Sufficiency in Him
  - D. His Headship
- **III. Behold Your Share in Christ (2:11–14)**
  - A. Circumcision Without Hands (2:11)
  - B. Burial and Resurrection with Him (2:12)
  - C. Forgiveness of All Transgressions (2:13)
  - D. The Debt Canceled (2:14)
- **IV. Be Awake to the Fate of the Powers (2:15)**
  - A. He Disarmed Them
  - B. He Made a Public Display of Them
  - C. He Triumphed over Them

Introduction

In 2:4 Paul warned against "persuasive argument." Now he names it: "philosophy and empty deception." Then, as he so often does, he answers error not merely with a warning but with a stunning portrait of Christ. We may follow his thought in four movements: Beware of philosophy (v.8), be aware of Christ (vv.9–10), behold your share in Christ (vv.11–14), and be awake to the fate of the demonic powers (v.15).

I. Beware of Philosophy (2:8)

"See to it that no one takes you captive through philosophy." Paul is not condemning all careful thinking or the love of wisdom as such. He is condemning this falsely named wisdom. Bishop Lightfoot suggested that Paul was flinging back at the false teachers a

favorite term of their own, their much-vaunted "philosophy." The verb "takes you captive" (*sylagōgeō*) means to carry off as booty, to kidnap. False teachers are not just mistaken; they are spiritual kidnappers who want to carry believers away from the truth into the slavery of error. Cults tend to treat converts as trophies, and their ministry is mostly among people who already have some knowledge of Christ.

The words "no one" (*tis*, singular) may hint at a particular leader in Colossae. Paul describes this philosophy four ways:

A. It Is Deceptive

"And empty deception." The philosophy is hollow (*kenos*), with no real substance behind it, and its purpose is to deceive (*apatē*). It looks full but is empty.

B. It Is Man-Made

"According to the tradition of men." Some religions are entirely man-made, notions people have invented. Others borrow some biblical truth to make their error more palatable. The latter was the case in Colossae. Jesus faced the same thing in the Pharisees, who had set aside God's commandment to keep their tradition (Mark 7:8–9).

C. It Is Worldly

"According to the elementary principles of the world." The word *stoicheia* means the elementary things, the ABCs, the basic components. It may refer to rudimentary religious rules (compare Gal. 4:3, 9), or to the "elemental spirits" thought to control the universe. Either way, it is worldly thinking, the kind of explanation of reality that leaves God out. In our day it would include philosophies of origins that make God unnecessary.

D. It Is Not According to Christ

"Rather than according to Christ." The Colossian teachers included Christ in their system, but He was not enough. Anything that is not "according to Christ" is, in the end, against Him. The best protection is a full, biblical knowledge of who Christ is.

II. Be Aware of Christ (2:9–10)

The seriousness of this error brought forth one of the finest statements about the Person of Christ in the Bible.

A. His Deity

"For in Him all the fullness of Deity dwells." Jesus Christ is fully God: "all the fullness." It is a double statement, "all" and "fullness," so that nothing is left out. The word for Deity (*theotēs*) is a strong word found only here in the New Testament. It does not merely mean "divine qualities" but the very essence of being God. And that fullness "dwells" (*katoikei*, present tense): it is permanently at home in Him.

Some have argued that while the Son was in heaven He was God, but during His incarnation He emptied Himself of His deity, misusing Philippians 2:7. This is sometimes called the kenosis error. Paul shuts that door with a single word.

B. His Humanity

"In bodily form" (*sōmatikōs*). The fullness of God dwelt, and dwells, in the Person Jesus Christ in a real human body. He is fully God and fully man, one Person. That answers both errors we met in our first study: the Cerinthians, who denied He was God, and the Docetists, who denied He had a real body. That is good news, but the rest of the news is even better.

C. Our Sufficiency in Him

"And in Him you have been made complete." The word "complete" (*peplērōmenoi*) comes from the same root as "fullness" (*plērōma*). He is the fullness of God, and you have been made full in Him. The grammar (a periphrastic perfect) stresses a completed state that continues: you were made full, and you remain full. When you believed, Christ came to dwell in you and you were placed in Him. What can anyone add to the complete indwelling of the One who is the fullness of God? Nothing. You are completely full in Him.

D. His Headship

"And He is the head over all rule and authority." Someone will ask, "What about angels and evil spirits?" The false teachers made much of angelic beings. If matter is evil and spirit is good, man cannot go directly to God, so there must be a chain of mediators between man and God. Those intermediaries had to be appeased, prayed to, and in the end feared. Paul's answer: the same Person who is the fullness of God and your fullness is also Head over every rule and authority. Apart from Him, good angels cannot help you and evil angels cannot harm you.

III. Behold Your Share in Christ (2:11–14)

A. Circumcision Without Hands (2:11)

"And in Him you were also circumcised with a circumcision made without hands, in the removal of the body of the flesh by the circumcision of Christ." The false teachers apparently insisted on physical circumcision. Paul says believers have already been circumcised, not by the removal of a small piece of flesh, but by the removal of "the body of the flesh." This circumcision is:

- **Spiritual, not physical:** "made without hands."
- **Entire, not partial:** "the body of the flesh," not a fragment of it.
- **By Christ, not by man:** "the circumcision of Christ."

What believers were in Adam (sinful, fallen, and corrupt) was dealt a death blow in Christ. Now "in Christ" a believer is a new creation (2 Cor. 5:17), and having a new Head, he has a new authority for his life: not the Law of Moses but the life of Christ. This sets doctrine straight and makes room for right living. Correct doctrine does not guarantee excellent behavior, but heresy makes correct behavior impossible.

B. Burial and Resurrection with Him (2:12)

"Having been buried with Him in baptism, in which you were also raised up with Him through faith in the working of God, who raised Him from the dead." The baptism here, as in Romans

6:3–4, is understood in this study as Spirit baptism, the work described in 1 Corinthians 12:13:

> *“For by one Spirit we were all baptized into one body, whether Jews or Greeks, whether slaves or free, and we were all made to drink of one Spirit.”*
>
> — 1 Corinthians 12:13 (NASB95)

Notice the parallel: if the circumcision of verse 11 is spiritual (and all agree it is "made without hands"), then the baptism of verse 12 is spiritual as well. Water baptism is the beautiful picture of this spiritual reality. Immersion portrays burial with Christ, and coming up out of the water portrays resurrection to walk in newness of life (Rom. 6:4).

- When Jesus died, I died (Gal. 2:20).
- When Jesus was buried, I was buried.
- When Jesus was raised, I was raised.

And notice how it happened: "through faith in the working of God." The instrument is faith; the power is God's, the same power that raised Christ from the dead.

C. Forgiveness of All Transgressions (2:13)

1. Your past condition: dead

"When you were dead in your transgressions and the uncircumcision of your flesh." Compare Ephesians 2:1–3. "Transgressions" are missteps, what you had done. "The uncircumcision of your flesh" describes what you were: Gentiles outside the covenant, with an unchanged sinful nature.

2. Your present position: alive and forgiven

"He made you alive together with Him." This new life came at the moment of salvation, and it is "together with Him," sharing His resurrection life. "Having forgiven us all our transgressions." The key word, in context, is **all**. Since God has forgiven all our sins, we do not have to do anything more to get salvation or to keep it. Notice too that Paul switches from "you" to "us." He includes himself among the forgiven.

D. The Debt Canceled (2:14)

"Having canceled out the certificate of debt consisting of decrees against us, which was hostile to us; and He has taken it out of the way, having nailed it to the cross." The "certificate of debt" (*cheirographon*) was a handwritten IOU, a signed acknowledgment of debt. Here it refers to the Law with its decrees, which man had broken and which stood as a witness against us.

God did three things with it. He "canceled" it, the word for wiping a writing surface clean. He "has taken it out of the way" (perfect tense: removed, and it stays removed). And He nailed it to the cross. When a man was crucified, the charge against him was often posted on the cross (John 19:19). The picture is vivid: our debt was posted on Christ's cross, and He paid it in full with His life. Christ died for the Law that mankind had broken. As far as our standing before God is concerned, that debt no longer exists. It is a beautiful figure for a beautiful doctrine.

IV. Be Awake to the Fate of the Powers (2:15)

Remember the "rule and authority" of verse 10? Paul now tells what happened to the hostile ones.

A. He Disarmed Them

"When He had disarmed the rulers and authorities." The verb (*apekdyomai*) means to strip off, as one strips a defeated soldier of his armor and weapons. They have no power over the believer. As a result, believers are delivered from the evil powers that inspire legalistic rules about foods and festivals (which Paul addresses next, 2:16). All foods are "created to be gratefully shared in by those who believe and know the truth," and the teaching that forbids them comes from "deceitful spirits and doctrines of demons" (1 Tim. 4:1–3).

Some try to divide the Law into "ceremonial" and "moral" parts and pick which ones still bind Christians. In the understanding followed here, the Law was given as a unit and was set aside as a unit for the believer's rule of life (2 Cor. 3:7–11; Heb. 7:11–12, 18–19; 8:13). The believer is not lawless; he lives under the law of Christ (1 Cor. 9:21; Gal. 6:2), and the moral righteousness of God is restated throughout the New Testament.

B. He Made a Public Display of Them

"He made a public display of them, having triumphed over them through Him." The picture is a Roman triumph. A victorious general returned from battle and marched through the streets of the capital: first the general, then his soldiers, then the captured enemies, stripped and paraded for all to see (compare 2 Cor. 2:14). The war was waged at the cross. Satan tried to keep Jesus from the cross; Jesus went there anyway and triumphed over them there.

C. He Triumphed over Them

His triumph sealed the doom of all evil, including Satan and his followers, then and now, angelic or human. The Colossians, and all believers with them, have nothing more to fear from these hostile powers.

Conclusion

Many believers still live under the shadow of signs, charms, and superstitions. They imagine unseen powers ruling nature in a thousand ways, ready to help or harm unless they do this or avoid that. Some religious broadcasters even feed that fear by offering, for a gift, to pray against such spirits. When will believers learn that "greater is He who is in you than he who is in the world" (1 John 4:4)?

In Christ dwells all the fullness of Deity in bodily form, and in Him you have been made complete. Your sins are forgiven, your debt is canceled, and your enemies are disarmed. Beware of anything that is not according to Christ.

Lord, thank You.

④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text

Greek Word Study

Grammar and parsing: Blue Letter Bible. Sources cited selectively: STR (Strong's), THAY (Thayer's), ATR (A. T. Robertson), VINE (Vine's), MRV (Vincent's), LXX (Septuagint usage).

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # / Transliteration / Form	Definition & Significance
v.8	**συλαγωγέω** *takes captive*	**G4812** *sylagōgeō* Pres. Act. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Sg.	**THAY:** to carry off as booty, lead captive. Only here in the NT. **Significance:** False teachers are spiritual kidnappers carrying believers into error.
v.8	**φιλοσοφία** *philosophy*	**G5385** *philosophia* Gen. Fem. Sg.	**MRV:** likely the false teachers' own term for their system. **Significance:** Not all thinking, but this particular counterfeit wisdom.
v.8	**ἀπάτη** *deception*	**G539** *apatē* Gen. Fem. Sg.	**STR:** delusion, deceitfulness. **Significance:** Paired with *kenos* (empty): hollow and misleading.
v.8	**στοιχεῖον** *elementary principles*	**G4747** *stoicheion* Acc. Neut. Pl.	**VINE:** first things, rudiments; possibly elemental spirits. **Significance:** Worldly basics that leave God out (cf. 2:20; Gal. 4:3).
v.9	**θεότης** *Deity*	**G2320** *theotēs* Gen. Fem. Sg.	**THAY:** the state of being God, Godhead. Only here in the NT. **VINE:** essence of deity, stronger than *theiotēs* (Rom. 1:20). **Significance:** Christ possesses the very essence of God, not merely divine qualities.
v.9	**σωματικῶς** *in bodily form*	**G4985** *sōmatikōs* Adverb	**STR:** corporeally, physically. **Significance:** Deity dwells in Christ's real human body; refutes both Docetism and kenosis.
v.10	**πληρόω** *made complete*	**G4137** *plēroō* Perf. Pass. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Pl. (periphrastic)	**ATR:** periphrastic perfect: a completed and continuing state. **Significance:** Same root as *plērōma*: He is the fullness; you are made full in Him.
v.11	**περιτέμνω** *circumcised*	**G4059** *peritemnō* Aor. Pass. Ind. 2nd Pl.	**LXX:** the covenant rite (Gen. 17); "circumcise your heart" (Deut. 10:16). **Significance:** Believers already have a spiritual circumcision; no physical rite is needed.
v.11	**ἀχειροποίητος** *made without hands*	**G886** *acheiropoiētos* Dat. Fem. Sg.	**STR:** not made by hand, spiritual. **Significance:** Spiritual, entire, and by Christ, not by man.
v.12	**συνθάπτω** *buried with*	**G4916** *synthaptō* Aor. Pass. Ptc. Nom.	**VINE:** to bury together with (also Rom. 6:4). **Significance:** Union with Christ in His burial, pictured by water baptism.

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # / Transliteration / Form	Definition & Significance
		Masc. Pl.	
v.13	**συζωοποιέω** *made alive together*	**G4806** *syzōopoieō* Aor. Act. Ind. 3rd Sg.	**STR:** to make alive together with. **Significance:** New life at salvation, sharing Christ's resurrection life.
v.13	**χαρίζομαι** *having forgiven*	**G5483** *charizomai* Aor. Mid. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Sg.	**THAY:** to grant as a favor, to pardon graciously; related to *charis*. **Significance:** Forgiveness is an act of grace, and it covers "all our transgressions."
v.14	**χειρόγραφον** *certificate of debt*	**G5498** *cheirographon* Acc. Neut. Sg.	**MRV:** a handwritten note of debt, a signed IOU. **Significance:** The Law's decrees as a written charge against us, now canceled.
v.14	**προσηλόω** *nailed*	**G4338** *prosēloō* Aor. Act. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Sg.	**STR:** to nail to. Only here in the NT. **Significance:** The debt was posted on the cross and paid in full.
v.15	**ἀπεκδύομαι** *disarmed*	**G554** *apekdyomai* Aor. Mid. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Sg.	**VINE:** to strip off, as arms from a defeated foe. **Significance:** Hostile powers are stripped of power over the believer.
v.15	**θριαμβεύω** *triumphed*	**G2358** *thriambeuō* Aor. Act. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Sg.	**THAY:** to lead in a triumphal procession (also 2 Cor. 2:14). **Significance:** A Roman triumph: the defeated powers paraded publicly.

Grammar key — Cases: Nom. · Gen. · Dat. · Acc. · Voc. | Number: Sg. · Pl. | Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut. Verb Mood: Ind. · Imp. · Subj. · Opt. · Inf. · Ptc. | Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. · Perf. · Plpf. | Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass. | Person: 1st/2nd/3rd Sg./Pl.

Study Questions

Part 1 — From the Commentary

Review prompt	From the commentary
Give four marks of the philosophy Paul condemns (v.8).	Deceptive, man-made, worldly, not according to Christ.
What two words of verse 9 refute the kenosis error and Docetism?	"Deity" (*theotēs*, the essence of God) and "bodily" (*sōmatikōs*).
How are "fullness" and "complete" related?	Same root: He is the *plērōma*; you have been made full (*peplērōmenoi*) in Him.
Describe the circumcision of verse 11.	Spiritual (without hands), entire (the body of the flesh), by Christ.

Review prompt	From the commentary
What three things did God do with the certificate of debt?	Canceled it, took it out of the way, and nailed it to the cross.

Part 2 — Study Questions

1. Why does Paul describe the false teachers with a verb meaning "kidnap" or "carry off as booty"?

Leader's answer: To show the danger: they were not offering harmless extras but carrying believers away from the truth into the slavery of error, treating them as trophies.

2. How do the words "Deity" and "bodily form" in verse 9 answer the errors of the Colossian heresy and later errors?

Leader's answer: *Theotēs* affirms that Christ has the full essence of God (against Cerinthian-type denial and kenosis), and *sōmatikōs* affirms a real body (against Docetism). He is fully God and fully man.

3. If believers are "made complete" in Christ (v.10), what does that mean for any teaching that offers something more?

Leader's answer: It is unnecessary at best and harmful at worst. Believers already possess fullness in Christ; nothing can be added to the indwelling of the One who is the fullness of God.

4. What reasons does the study give for understanding the baptism of verse 12 as Spirit baptism, and how does water baptism relate to it?

Leader's answer: Verse 11's circumcision is spiritual ("made without hands"), so the parallel baptism is too; 1 Cor. 12:13 describes Spirit baptism into Christ's body. Water baptism pictures it: burial and resurrection with Christ.

5. How does the picture of the certificate of debt nailed to the cross bring assurance to a believer?

Leader's answer: Our written debt under the Law was canceled, removed, and paid in full at the cross. Since God has forgiven "all our transgressions," nothing remains to be paid to obtain or keep salvation.

Part 3 — Passage Summary

Verses	Theme	Key truth
2:8	Beware of philosophy	Empty, man-made, worldly teaching that is not according to Christ.
2:9–10	Be aware of Christ	All the fullness of Deity dwells in Him bodily; believers are complete in Him; He is Head over all powers.
2:11–14	Behold your share	Spiritual circumcision, union in burial and resurrection, full forgiveness, the debt canceled.
2:15	The powers defeated	Rulers and authorities disarmed, displayed, and triumphed over through Christ.

⑤ APPLICATION

Closes the study · personal and corporate

1. Test Every Teaching by "According to Christ"

Scripture anchor: Colossians 2:8

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, I

Paul gives us a simple test: is this teaching according to Christ, or according to human tradition and the world's basic principles? Many voices today mix a little Christian language with a lot of human philosophy. Measure everything by who Christ is and what He has done.

Reflection: What books, podcasts, or voices are shaping your thinking about God right now? Are they "according to Christ"?

Practical step: Evaluate one source of spiritual teaching you regularly use against Colossians 1:15–20 and 2:9–10.

2. Live from Fullness, Not Toward It

Scripture anchor: Colossians 2:10

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, II.C, and ② Devotional

You have been made complete in Christ. Spiritual growth is not about getting more of Christ but about Christ getting more of you, as you learn to live out the fullness you already have. That frees you from restless searching and lets you serve from security.

Reflection: In what area do you feel spiritually "incomplete"? How does verse 10 speak to that feeling?

Practical step: Memorize Colossians 2:9–10 this week and recite it whenever you feel spiritually inadequate.

3. Remember the Nailed Debt

Scripture anchor: Colossians 2:13–14

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, III.C–D; cf. Hodges, Absolutely Free (FGR)

God forgave "all our transgressions" and nailed the certificate of debt to the cross. Zane Hodges often stressed that the gift of eternal life is absolutely free precisely because Christ paid absolutely everything. Believers confess sin to restore fellowship (1 John 1:9), but never to re-earn a salvation already paid for.

Reflection: Is there a sin from your past you still treat as an unpaid debt?

Practical step: Write that sin on a slip of paper, read verse 14 aloud over it, and then destroy the paper as a reminder that the debt is canceled.

4. Refuse to Fear Defeated Powers

Scripture anchor: Colossians 2:15; 1 John 4:4

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, IV and Conclusion

The rulers and authorities have been disarmed and paraded in defeat. Believers need not be ruled by superstitions, charms, or fear of unseen forces. Spiritual warfare is real, but we fight from victory, not for it.

Reflection: Do any superstitions or fears of the unseen still influence your choices?

Practical step: Thank Christ aloud each day this week for His triumph at the cross over every hostile power.

End of Study · Colossians 2:8–15